

Memo: Positional Value and Scarcity Across EFA, EDSL, and MLS History

League-history study using franchise-season performance, trade logs, waiver activity, and rookie drafts

Prepared from fantasy_league_reports_normalized.xlsx

Scope and method

Sample: 805 franchise-seasons across 2019-2025 ({'EDSL': 369, 'EFA': 368, 'MLS': 68}).

Outcome metrics: all-play win rate and within-season power-rank percentile.

Position room strength: active-roster season points by position; star thresholds use the top individual scorer at each position.

Market lens: 2850 trade log entries, 263 clean player-for-pick price samples, 15950 unique waiver/add-drop acquisitions, and 3652 non-MLS rookie picks.

Limitation: player age is not present in the workbook, so rookie draft results are used as the best available age-proxy.

Executive read

- RB and LB were the clearest winning positions. A top-quartile RB room lifted all-play win rate by 19.8 points; LB added 18.8.
- TE was more of a scarcity position than a volume-trade position. Top-quartile TE rooms added 14.4 points, but the clean trade market only priced TE at 97.0 pick-equivalent points on average.
- WR remained expensive and important: the league moved 1450 WR trade assets, and top-quartile WR rooms gained 13.0 all-play points.
- QB mattered, but the evidence does not say you must overpay. A 400+ QB helped (+12.2), yet the overall QB room signal (10.3) lagged RB, LB, TE, and WR.
- CB was the clearest low-value spot. Top-quartile CB rooms actually underperformed the field by 2.7 points, while waiver and late-draft replacement rates were the best in the dataset.
- True position changed the composition of defense, but not the core answer. Post-2021, LB still beat DE by a wide margin (19.0 vs 6.1).

1. What actually drove winning

The cleanest test was simple: within each season, take the teams in the top quartile at a position and compare their all-play results to everyone else. That treats each position room as a roster-building decision rather than a single-player anecdote.

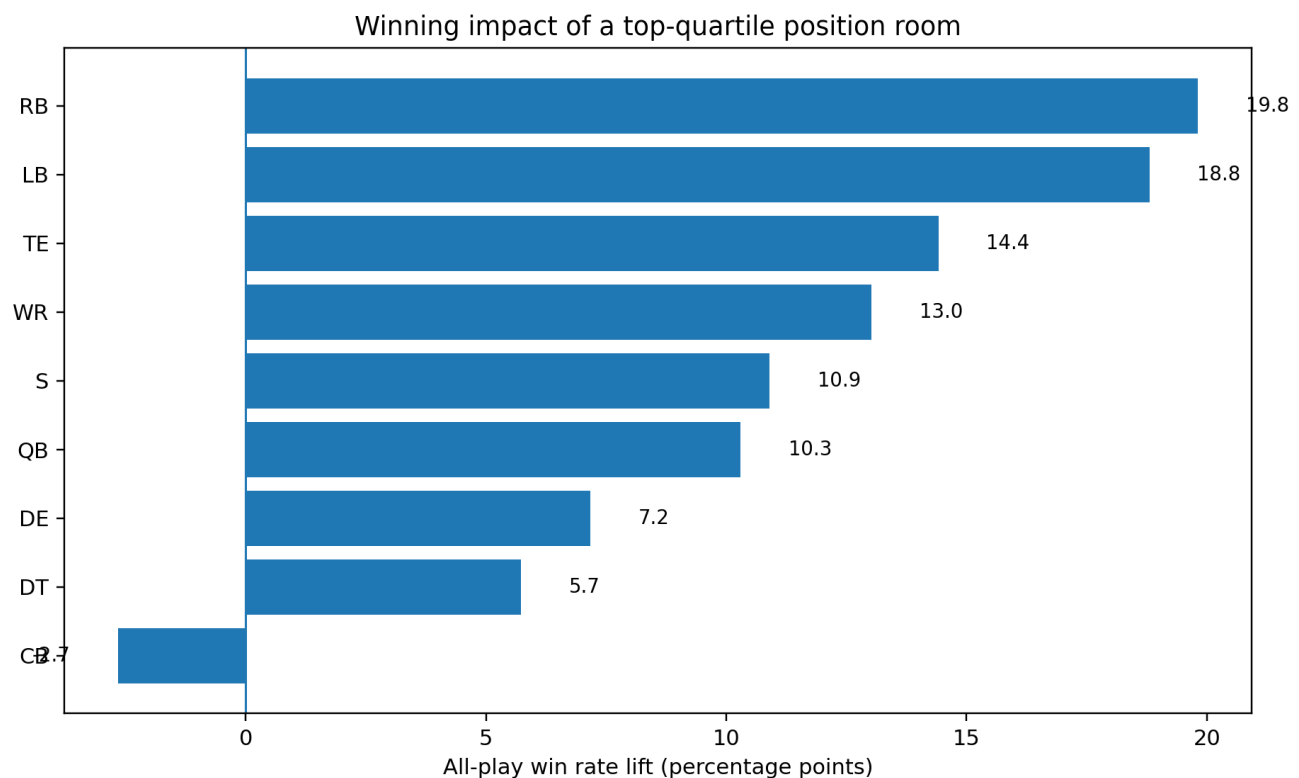


Figure 1. All-play win rate lift from fielding a top-quartile room at each position.

- RB (19.8) and LB (18.8) were the two clearest paths to winning.
- TE (14.4) beat QB (10.3), which is why TE should be treated as a scarcity position, not as a throwaway.
- S and QB were useful middle-tier positions: positive, but not strong enough to justify reckless capital concentration.
- DE and DT helped less than league rhetoric often suggests, and CB was the only room that came back negative.

Pos	All-play lift	Power lift	Trade price	Waiver 150+	Late-draft 150+	Read
QB	10.3	15.3	106.6	3.0%	8.3%	Fairly aligned; Moderate
RB	19.8	27.7	135.3	1.2%	5.5%	Fairly aligned; Hard
WR	13.0	18.6	134.4	1.1%	2.2%	Likely overpriced; Hard
TE	14.4	19.3	97.0	1.7%	0.0%	Likely underpriced; Hard

LB	18.8	26.4	107.6	5.8%	3.1%	Likely underpriced; Hard
DE	7.2	8.9	129.6	16.4%	4.7%	Likely overpriced; Moderate
DT	5.7	9.2	77.3	21.9%	3.3%	Fairly aligned; Moderate
S	10.9	15.5	69.3	24.5%	28.5%	Likely underpriced; Easy
CB	-2.7	-2.2	59.6	34.5%	43.4%	Fairly aligned; Easy

Table 1. Core position summary. Trade price is the average value paid in clean player-for-pick deals, measured in rookie-point equivalents. Waiver and late-draft columns show 150+ hit rates.

2. Does elite star power matter more than depth?

The next question is whether one elite scorer changes team outcomes by itself. The heatmap below shows the lift from having at least one 200+, 300+, or 400+ scorer at each position. Higher numbers mean the threshold historically moved winning more.

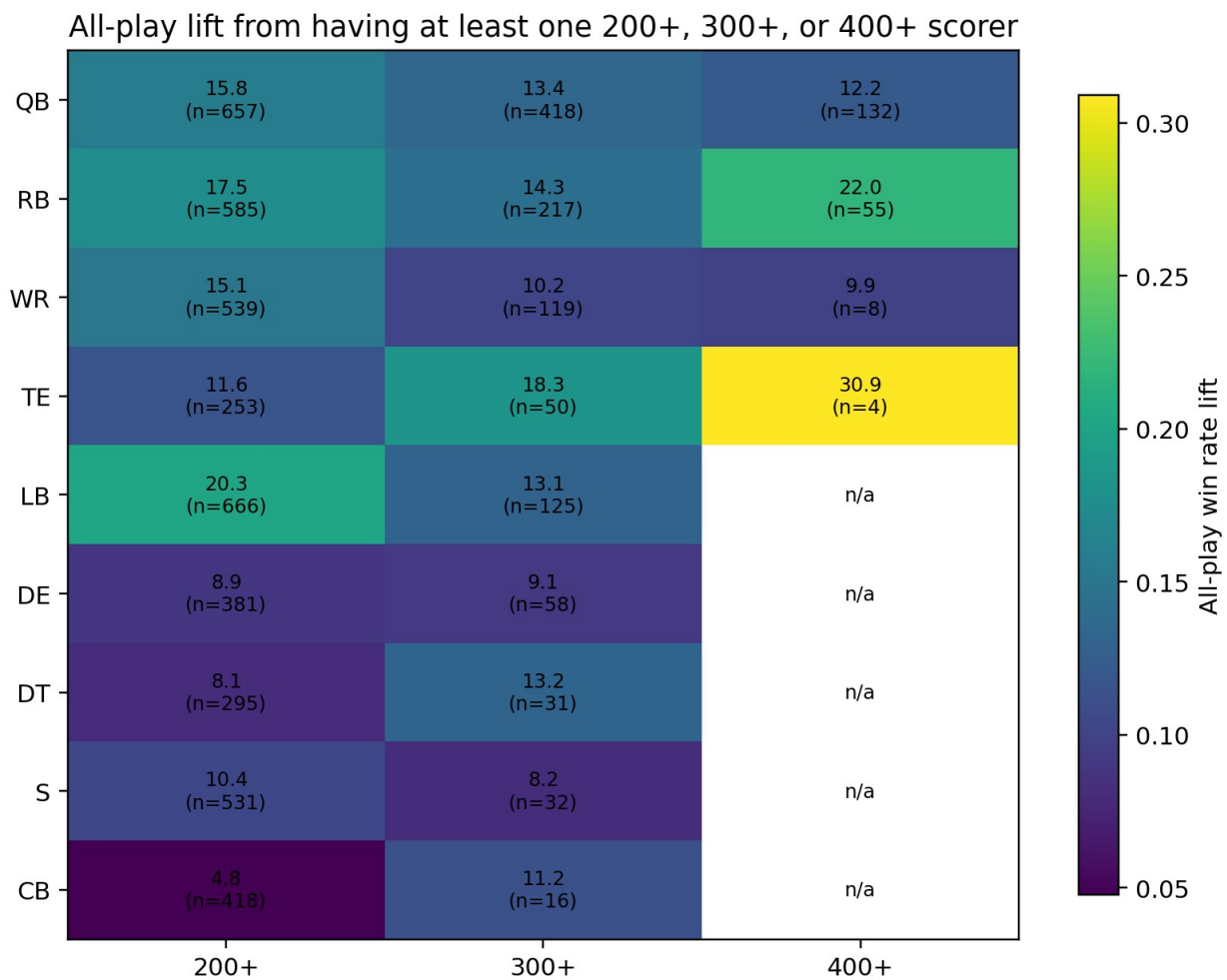


Figure 2. All-play lift from having at least one threshold scorer. Cell labels show lift and sample size.

- A 400+ RB was the cleanest star signal in the dataset (+22.0, n=55).
- A 400+ QB helped, but not enough to dominate the roster conversation (+12.2, n=132).
- A 300+ TE was powerful (+18.3), and the tiny 400+ TE sample was enormous (+30.9, n=4).
- For WR and LB, the broader room still mattered more than simply chasing one mega-season. Those positions rewarded depth and lineup volume, not just a single hammer.

3. What the league paid for vs where replacement actually existed

The trade market and the replacement market do not tell the same story. The chart below compares clean trade price to actual winning impact. Bubble size reflects how often that position moved in any trade.

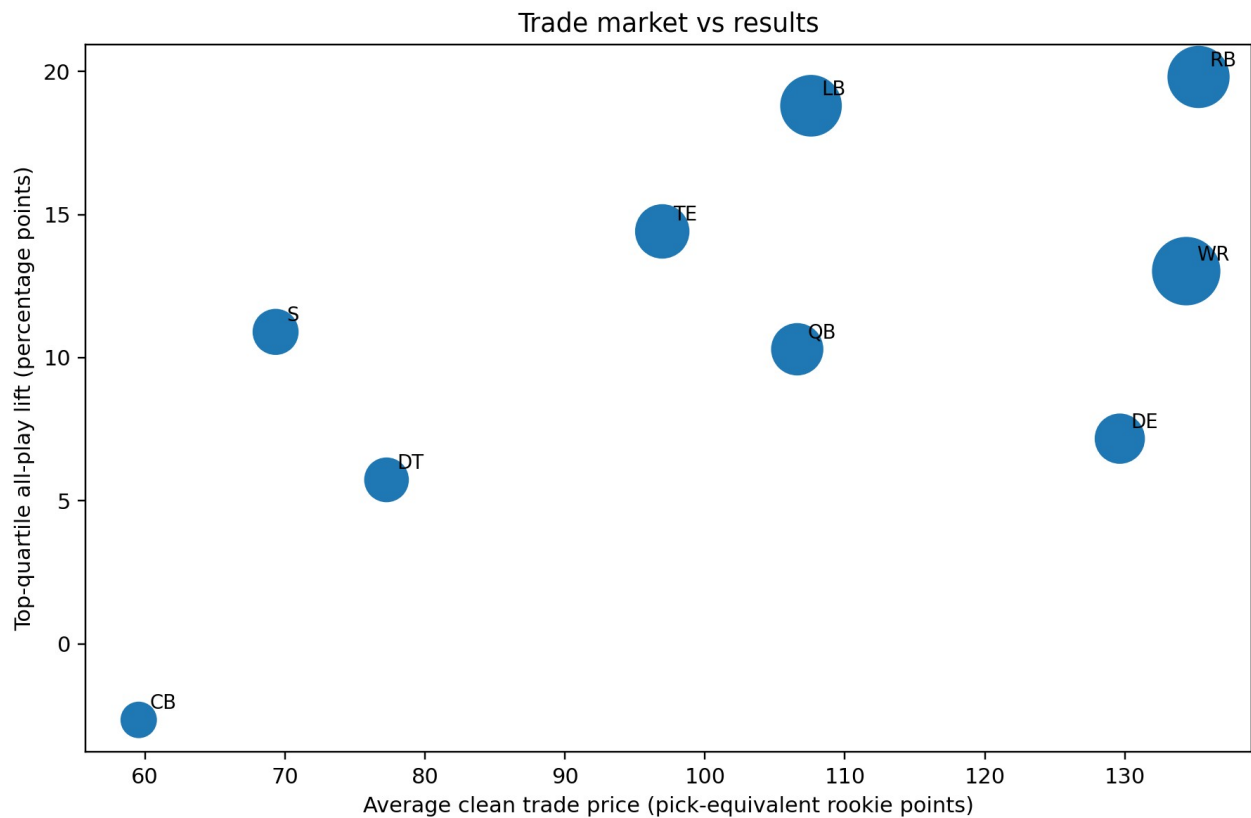


Figure 3. Trade market vs results. Expensive positions in the lower-right are the best candidates for market overpayment.

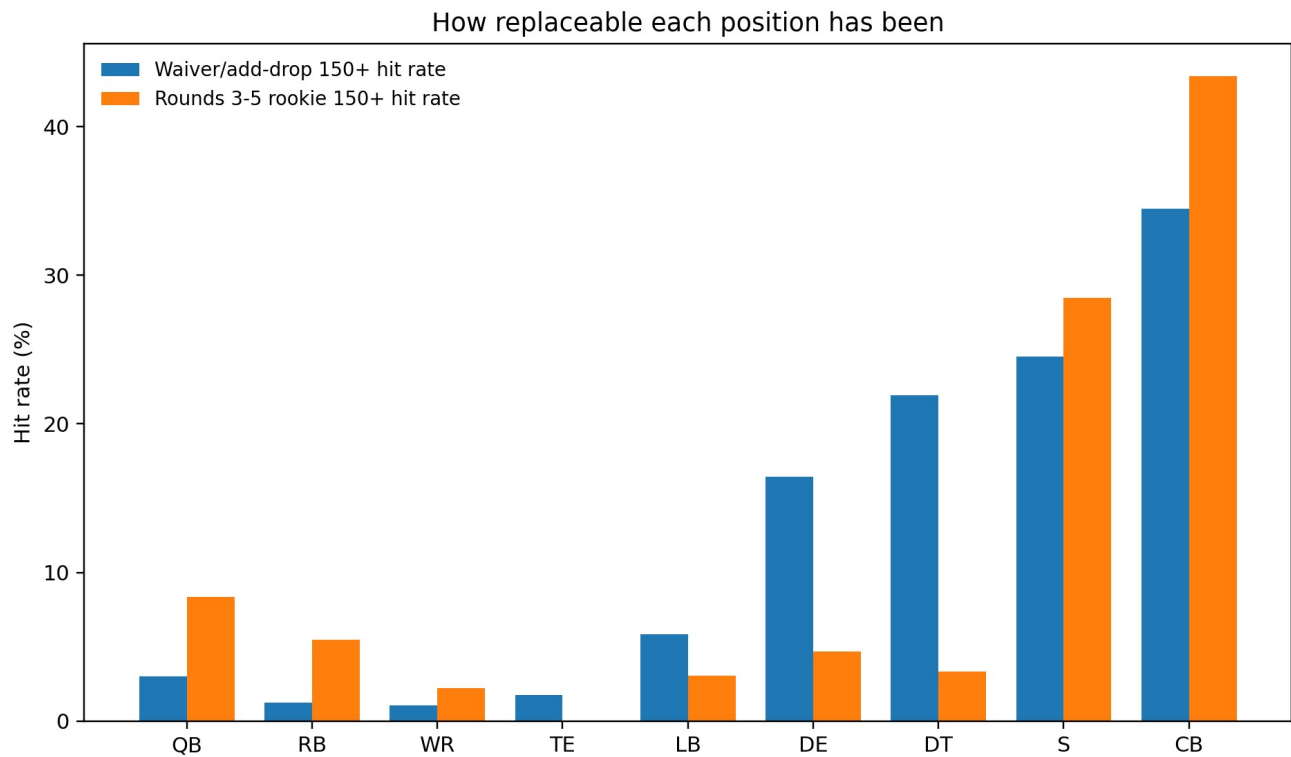


Figure 4. Replaceability by waiver/add-drop and by late rookie picks (Rounds 3-5).

- WR and RB were expensive for good reason, but WR priced even richer than its results rank while still being nearly impossible to replace late (2.2% late-draft 150+ hit rate).
- LB looked materially underpriced. It ranked #2 in winning impact, but only #4 in clean trade price.
- TE also looked underpriced by market rank and hard to rescue later (0.0% late-draft 150+ hit rate; 1.7% waiver 150+ hit rate).
- DE was one of the most likely overpays: third-highest trade price (129.6), but only seventh in winning lift.
- CB and S were the classic churn positions. They were easiest to solve on waivers and easiest to hit in late rookie rounds, which is exactly why they should rarely consume premium capital.

4. Did true position rewrite the rules?

It changed roster composition, but it did not overturn the main build logic.

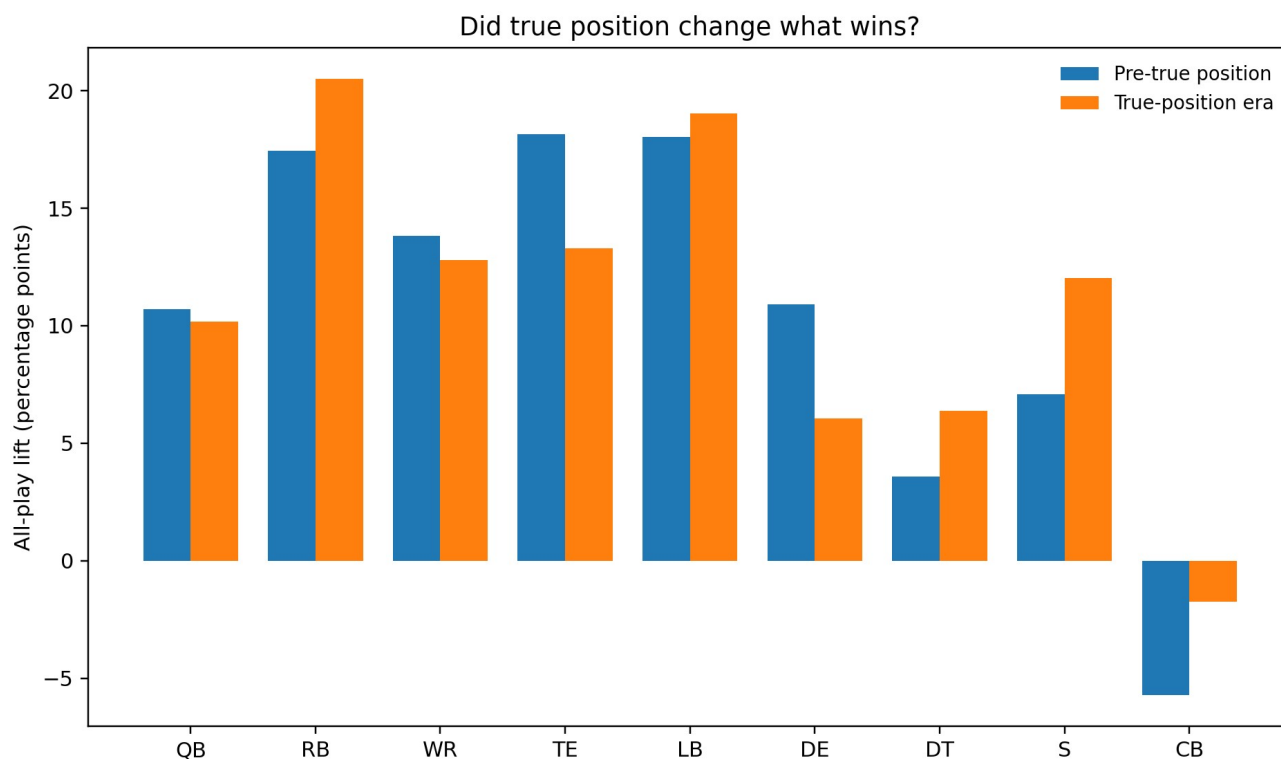


Figure 5. Pre- and post-2021 all-play lift from top-quartile position rooms.

- LB depth did shrink after the rule shift (average active LB count fell from 6.70 to 5.92 per team), but LB still remained an elite winning position (18.0 pre vs 19.0 post).
- DE scoring became somewhat richer (average active DE points rose from 454.4 to 509.8), but DE still did not catch LB in outcome strength (10.9 pre; 6.1 post).
- The practical meaning: true position changed defensive plumbing, not the central investment hierarchy. You still win more often by being strong at RB/LB/WR than by chasing edge-only builds.

5. Practical roster-build memo

If the goal is to maximize title odds, the history points to this sequence

1) Pay most willingly for RB, WR, and LB. Those are the clearest winning engines, and they are not easy to repair late.

2) Solve TE on purpose. You do not necessarily need the best TE, but punting the room has historically been expensive.

3) Secure a real QB1, but be careful about luxury QB spending. The league history does not support going crazy for QB2/QB3 depth.

4) Avoid sinking premium capital into CB. S and DT are also better handled with churn, timing, and volume than with stars-and-scrubs spending.

5) Treat DE carefully. Buy it when the price is soft or when the league underreacts, but the historical record does not support DE as a primary spending pillar.

6. Position-by-position call sheet

Position	Recommended stance	Why
RB	Primary spend	Best overall win signal; 400+ RB seasons mattered most.
WR	Primary spend	High demand and very hard to replace late.
LB	Primary spend	Major underpriced winner if the league discounts it.
TE	Scarcity spend	Scarcity room; punting it is dangerous.
QB	Anchor spend	Buy one anchor; avoid luxury depth spending.
DE	Selective spend	Useful, but often priced like a core pillar.
S	Churn / opportunistic	Often replaceable through churn.
DT	Churn / opportunistic	Usually more patchable than trade rhetoric suggests.
CB	Do not pay	Lowest-value premium spend in the file.

Appendix A. Threshold table

Pos	Threshold	Teams	All-play lift
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QB	200+	657	15.8
QB	300+	418	13.4
QB	400+	132	12.2
RB	200+	585	17.5
RB	300+	217	14.3
RB	400+	55	22.0
WR	200+	539	15.1
WR	300+	119	10.2
WR	400+	8	9.9
TE	200+	253	11.6
TE	300+	50	18.3
TE	400+	4	30.9
LB	200+	666	20.3
LB	300+	125	13.1
LB	400+	0	n/a
DE	200+	381	8.9
DE	300+	58	9.1
DE	400+	0	n/a
DT	200+	295	8.1
DT	300+	31	13.2
DT	400+	0	n/a
S	200+	531	10.4
S	300+	32	8.2
S	400+	0	n/a
CB	200+	418	4.8
CB	300+	16	11.2
CB	400+	0	n/a

Appendix B. Trade-price and replaceability table

Pos	Clean trade samples	Avg trade price	Waiver 150+	Late-draft 150+	Market view
QB	41	106.6	3.0%	8.3%	Fairly aligned

RB	39	135.3	1.2%	5.5%	Fairly aligned
WR	81	134.4	1.1%	2.2%	Likely overpriced
TE	23	97.0	1.7%	0.0%	Likely underpriced
LB	44	107.6	5.8%	3.1%	Likely underpriced
DE	20	129.6	16.4%	4.7%	Likely overpriced
DT	6	77.3	21.9%	3.3%	Fairly aligned
S	6	69.3	24.5%	28.5%	Likely underpriced
CB	3	59.6	34.5%	43.4%	Fairly aligned